

General Knowledge

Art & Culture

STUDY NOTES

Puppetry in India



PUPPETRY IN INDIA



Introduction

- **Puppetry in India** is an ancient art form with rich cultural significance, used for storytelling, entertainment, and moral instruction.
- **References to puppetry** can be found in **Harappa, Mohenjo-Daro excavations**, and **ancient texts** like the **Silappadikaram** and **Mahabharata**.
- Puppetry represents **philosophical ideas**, such as in the **Bhagavad Gita**, where God is depicted as a puppeteer managing the universe with strings of **Satta, Raja, and Tama**.
- Puppetry incorporates **local art forms** like **painting, dance, sculpture, and theatre** across regions.

Salient Features of Indian Puppetry

- **Themes:** Based on **epics, myths, and local folklore**.
- **Regional Influence:** Puppets reflect **local art styles**, costumes, and dialects.
- **Music:** Traditional instruments and folk songs accompany performances.

- **Language:** Adapted into **regional languages**, while maintaining connections with **Sanskrit drama** traditions.
- **Ceremonial Significance:** Often performed at **festivals, weddings, and celebrations**.

Types of Puppets in India

Type of Puppet	Description	Examples (State)
String Puppets (Marionettes) 	Controlled with strings attached to limbs, allowing more movement. Made of wood, with vibrant costumes and lifelike features.	Kathputli (Rajasthan): Wooden dolls with regional music. Bommalattam (Tamil Nadu): Largest marionettes, manipulated by rings worn on the head. Gombeyatta (Karnataka): Styled after Yakshagana theatre. Kundhei (Odisha): Wooden puppets with flowing skirts.
Shadow Puppets 	Flat leather puppets pressed against a lit screen, casting shadows. Puppets often have no joints, making manipulation challenging.	Tholu Bommalata (Andhra Pradesh): Colorful leather figures with jointed parts. Togalu Gombeyatta (Karnataka): Size varies with the character's status. Ravanachhaya (Odisha): Made from deer skin, creating lyrical shadows.
Rod Puppets	Supported and manipulated by rods. Often larger than glove puppets and popular in Bengal and Odisha.	Putul Nautch (West Bengal): Rod puppets with elaborate costumes. Yampuri (Bihar): Solid wooden puppets with no joints.

		Odisha Rod Puppets: Smaller, combining elements of string and rod puppets.
Glove Puppets 	Manipulated by hands inside the puppet, like a glove. Movements are controlled with fingers.	Pavakoothu (Kerala): Inspired by Kathakali dance. Glove Puppets (Uttar Pradesh, Odisha): Present social and religious themes.

Significant Puppet Forms by State

- **Kathputli (Rajasthan):**
 - Made of wood, dressed in **Rajasthani outfits**, often lacking legs.
 - Accompanied by **dramatic folk music**.
 - Themes are drawn from **local folklore** and epics.
- **Tholu Bommalata (Andhra Pradesh):**
 - **Leather puppets**, coloured on both sides for shadow effects.
 - Performances revolve around **epics like the Ramayana and Mahabharata**.
- **Bommalattam (Tamil Nadu):**
 - **Largest and heaviest puppets** in India, up to 10 kg.
 - Combines elements of **rod and string puppets**.
 - Performances include elaborate preliminaries.

State	Name of Puppet Form	Type of Puppet Form
Rajasthan	Kathputli	String Puppet
Odisha	Kundhei	String Puppet

Odisha	Gopalila Kundhei	String Puppet
Odisha	Ravanachhaya	Shadow Puppet
Assam	Putul Nach	String Puppet
West Bengal	Putul Nach	Rod Puppet
West Bengal	Rod Puppetry	Rod Puppet
Bihar	Yampuri	Rod Puppet
Karnataka	Gombeyatta	String Puppet
Karnataka	Togalu Gombeyatta	Shadow Puppet
Tamil Nadu	Bommalattam	String Puppet
Tamil Nadu	Thol Bommalattam	Shadow Puppet
Andhra Pradesh	Tholu Bommalata	Shadow Puppet
Kerala	Pavakoothu	Glove Puppet
Kerala	Tholpavakoothu	Shadow Puppet
Maharashtra	Kalasutri Bahulya	String Puppet
Maharashtra	Chamadyache Bahulya	Shadow Puppet
Gujarat	Kathputli (Regional Variation)	String Puppet
Uttar Pradesh	Social Glove Puppetry	Glove Puppet
Telangana	Tolu Bommalata	Shadow Puppet
Chhattisgarh	Rod Puppetry	Rod Puppet
Nagaland	Tribal Puppet Performances	Rod Puppet
Madhya Pradesh	Shadow Puppet Performances	Shadow Puppet

Some of the popular versions of puppetry from all over India

NO STRINGS ATTACHED

RAJASTHAN

Kathputli
(Technique: String)

UTTAR PRADESH

Glove puppets

ASSAM

Putala Natch
(String)

MAHARASHTRA

Kalasutri Bahulya
(String)
Chamadyache
Bahulya (Shadow)

MANIPUR

Laithibi Jagoi
(String)

KARNATAKA

Gombeyatta (String)
Togalu Gombeyaata
(Shadow)

WEST BENGAL

Putul Nautch
(Rod)

TAMIL NADU

Bommallattam (Rod+String)

BIHAR

Yampuri
(Rod)

ANDHRA PRADESH

Keelubommalatta
(String) Tholu
Bommallata (Shadow)

KERALA

Nool Pavakoothu (String)
Pavakoothu (Glove)

ODISHA

Gopalila Kundhei (String)
Ravanachhaya (Shadow)
Kathi Kandhe (Rod)

PUPPETRY TECHNIQUES

String Puppets

Jointed limbs
controlled by
strings

Rod Puppets

Large glove
puppets supported
by rods

Shadow Puppets

Operated against
a white cloth
screen

Glove Puppets

Worn on
hands

NEWS creative

Source: certindia

Modern Puppetry in India

- Modern puppetry emerged under the influence of the **Sergei Obratsov School (Russia)**.
- **Meher Contractor**, associated with **Darpana Academy (Gujarat)**, introduced **modern puppetry** to India.
- Contemporary puppetry connects **traditional puppet artists with global platforms**.

Challenges Faced by Puppetry Today

- **Lack of Patronage:** Financial support for puppeteers has dwindled.
- **Competition with Electronic Media:** Television and movies have diverted attention from traditional arts.
- **Limited Modern Relevance:** Traditional puppetry mainly focuses on **mythological themes**, lacking engagement with **contemporary social issues**.
- **Outdated Techniques:** Puppetry needs advancements in **lighting, sound, and stage effects** to attract modern audiences.